commitment Washington would have to make to maintain stability and promote prosperity in the Indo-Pacific.

It was not until the Obama administration that a new, overarching concept came to be articulated, the so-called pivot or rebalance to Asia. First rolled out by then secretary of state Hillary Clinton in an article titled "America's Pacific Century," the argument behind the pivot was repeated by President Barack Obama and a host of administration officials; they asserted that the United States would pursue a multipronged approach of military buildup, diplomatic engagement, and free-trade negotiation to shore up its position in Asia.[31] The pivot envisioned a renewed push for Sino-US cooperation, symbolized by the 2013 Sunnylands summit between Obama and new Chinese leader Xi Jinping. Yet by enhancing America's military presence in Asia, the pivot was interpreted by many, not least in China, as an attempt to contain a rising power.[32] Further, by publicly asserting that the United States had a "national interest" in seeing China and its neighbors peacefully resolve South China Sea territorial disputes, the Obama administration threatened to intervene in areas that Beijing considered to be core interests.[33]

China's response was not only to continue its rapid military modernization but to begin a massive land reclamation program in the contested Spratly Islands, creating islands out of submerged reefs and militarizing them with three-thousand-meter runways, defensive weaponry, radars, and porting facilities. China further continued its predatory cyberattacks on US businesses and was charged in the theft of the confidential personal information of over 22 million American citizens from the US Office of Personnel Management. Its repeated watering down and undermining of UN sanctions against North Korea, as well as its support for authoritarian regimes around the world, further strained ties with the United States.

As for North Korea, the Obama administration's policy of "strategic patience" resulted in largely eight years of neglect of the issue, with only one, quickly broken agreement (the so-called 2012 Leap Day